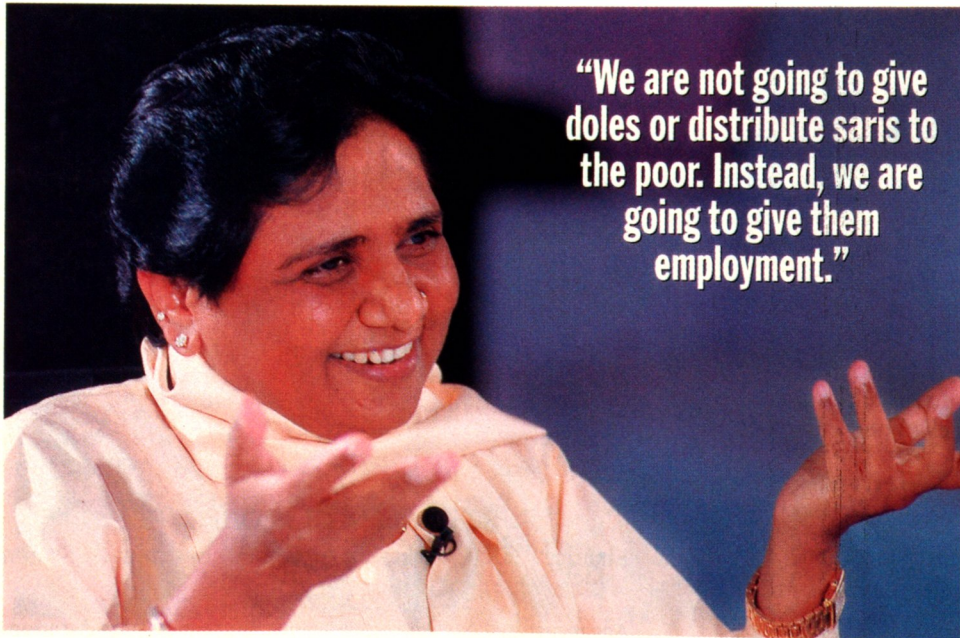


"My party MLAs will not adopt corrupt means to earn money"

Mayawati, who surprised political pundits and pollsters alike with her spectacular comeback in the elections held earlier this month, spoke to INDIA TODAY Editor PRABHU CHAWLA in an interview for AajTak and Headlines Today after taking over as Uttar Pradesh chief minister for a fourth time. Excerpts:

Q. It is only when one is in power that one realises the responsibility.

MAYAWATI



You are the first woman in India to have come to power without the support of any party. How big is the responsibility?

A. Whenever I have taken a major decision in my life, I have known that I will have to work very hard. It is after a lot of struggle that I have reached this stage. The BSP has neither allied with any other party nor taken anyone's support. The support of the entire society brought us to power. Our party's symbol is the elephant, and its weight, size and strength symbolise Uttar Pradesh.

Q. First Uttar Pradesh, what next? India?

A. You are saying it, not me. During the oath-taking ceremony,

people were chanting: "UP to hamari hai, ab Dilli ki bari hai (UP is ours, we will win Delhi now)".

Q. You said at your press conference, "Mare ko kya maarna (why kill someone who is already dead)". Now that you have politically killed the Opposition, how will you use that dagger while in power? To kill or to create a new Uttar Pradesh?

A. We will use political power as a tool to improve the lives of the people.

For years, Uttar Pradesh has been waiting to be turned into Uttam Pradesh, a developed state.

Q. Does the BSP have an agenda? An economic or political policy?

A. We will create an equitable society. Every policy will be development and justice-oriented.

Q. What is Mayawati's economic policy? Is it Capitalist or Marxist?

A. Our party's economic policy will be people-oriented. But our government will neither give doles to the poor and unemployed, nor distribute saris. We will give permanent employment. It will take time, but our economic policy will surely be for the poor, unemployed and suppressed.

Q. Don't you feel that while

Dalits, your real support base, toil in the fields, Brahmin leaders who are your new converts work in the comfort of air-conditioned rooms?

A. We have tried to bring upper caste people into our party, so the opposition has been misleading our best vote bank—the schedule castes—by saying that the upper castes will now change the BSP's policies against the Dalits. It has even tried to instigate them against my leadership.

Q. Will your government step in to acquire land for SEZs?

A. For the development of industries in the state, we will surely do it.

Q. What about SEZs announced by the previous government?

A. I will conduct inquiry in case I find any irregularity.

Q. Why do you want to turn the clock back?

A. How can we overlook the unlawful acts of the previous government? I got the votes due to two reasons. First, people have faith that I can enforce the rule of law. Second, they have full faith that I will unearth the misappropriations of the previous government.

Q. Is it true that you take money from your candidates in return for tickets?

A. It's absolutely incorrect. Every party has its strategy. I do not take money from industrial-

ists, so I told candidates to spend money on their own campaigns and also help the party financially in campaigning. I took money from candidates to evade pressure from industrialists after coming to power.

Q. If an MLA gives money, would he not use his power to earn it back?

A. I don't think they will adopt corrupt means to earn money.

Q. Who will you support in the Presidential elections—UPA or NDA?

A. We have not decided anything yet. Leaders are in touch with us. We will decide soon.

For full text of the interview, log on to

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